Omaha Platform

People's Party (Populist) National Convention · Omaha, NE · July 4, 1892

Source: Library of Congress; reprinted in The World Almanac and Encyclopedia 1893.

Drafted at the founding convention of the People's Party in 1892, the Omaha Platform was the most ambitious reform program of the 19th century. It blamed farmers' and workers' suffering on collusion between corporations and corrupt government, and demanded a flexible currency, government ownership of railroads and telegraphs, direct election of senators, an income tax, and the secret ballot. Most of its planks looked radical in 1892 but became law during the Progressive Era and New Deal.

> *Connect: The Populists' anti-monopoly rhetoric echoes Jackson's Bank War message (Class 11). Both movements attacked concentrated economic power. How are they similar? Different?*

Key Passages

Preamble (Ignatius Donnelly)

> We meet in the midst of a nation brought to the verge of moral, political, and material ruin. Corruption dominates the ballot-box, the Legislatures, the Congress, and touches even the ermine of the bench. The people are demoralized. … The fruits of the toil of millions are boldly stolen to build up colossal fortunes for a few, unprecedented in the history of mankind.

Currency plank

> We demand the free and unlimited coinage of silver and gold at the present legal ratio of 16 to 1. We demand that the amount of circulating medium be speedily increased to not less than $50 per capita.

Transportation plank

> Transportation being a means of exchange and a public necessity, the government should own and operate the railroads in the interest of the people.

Political reforms

> We demand a free ballot and a fair count in all elections … the election of Senators of the United States by direct vote of the people. … We favor a system of direct legislation through the initiative and referendum.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Agricultural depression, falling crop prices, debt, railroad monopolies, and the money supply; the Farmers' Alliances formed the People's Party.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Farmers, laborers, and voters in the South and West ahead of the 1892 election, along with the two major parties.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Populist leaders and farmers who saw corporations and banks as their oppressors; they looked for help from the federal government.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — Purpose (multi-doc): Using this platform and ONE other reform-era document, argue what reformers in the 1890s thought was wrong with the U.S.

2. Which planks of the Omaha Platform eventually became federal law? In which decades?

3. Why did the Populist Party itself collapse so quickly after 1896?